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EMPIRICAL ARTICLE

Do online discounts and free gifts damage brand image of service? The moderating role of promotion-proneness

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Abstract The present paper outlines a study based on an experimental design that investigated the effect of online price discounts and free gifts on consumers' evaluation of the brand, in the context of an airline. The study also analyzed whether promotion-proneness exercises a moderating effect on this relationship. It was found that discounts generate a more positive brand image than free gifts among promotion-prone users, while for less promotion-prone individuals, the opposite is true. The results will help managers to select the most appropriate online sales promotion type for reaching different consumer groups, depending on their promotion-proneness, in line with the needs and objectives of the service firm.

Keywords Brand image · Promotion-proneness · Online sales promotion · Online price discount · Online free gift

1 Introduction

Of all the different marketing communication tools that firms use on the Internet, online advertising is undoubtedly the most popular. Online advertising continues to witness relentless growth worldwide. Of the total investment in online advertising registered in the United States, the financial service sector accounts for 13 % and the travel sector accounts for 9 % ($1.3 billion), while in Europe the travel sector accounts for 9.60 % of the total invested in online advertising. The most popular online formats in Europe,

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across all sectors, are search engine advertising (48.8 %), followed by display advertising (32.4 %) (IAB 2013).

However, while advertising spend increases, its effectiveness is found to decline, as consumers find the never-ending barrage of advertising messages increasingly wearisome.

There are numerous studies and reports demonstrating the continued loss of effectiveness among certain online advertising formats (ComScore 2009; HubSpot 2013; IAB 2010). Among the reasons for this decline in effectiveness for traditional approaches to online advertising is the perceived irrelevance of the information conveyed by the ads, from the perspective of Internet users, translating into a lack of interest in this type of format (Bulik 2000; Gaffney 2001) and low CTR ratios.

Due to the Web becoming saturated with advertising, firms have been forced to find new and innovative ways to communicate online with their online target audiences. One such approach to differentiating themselves from the competition is that of online sales promotion, which has witnessed significant growth in recent years (Valassis 2011). According to a recent report from Nielsen (2013)—which is applicable for both traditional and online media—some 44 % of Europeans, in general, and 65 % of the Spanish, in particular, present a significant interest in buying products on special offer. In 2005, just 12 % of US homes used online coupons, but by 2011 this figure had risen to 22 %, and over 60 % of US consumers used online coupons for over 25 % of their online purchases (Forrester 2012).

While there are only scant data on the use of online sales promotions, it is even more difficult to find studies that provide a breakdown by sector, or that focus on the service sector specifically, for instance. One of the few existing works is a study by Groupalia, which showed that 52 % of users who tried a discounted service would be prepared to acquire it again even at its normal price (eMarket Services 2011), which indicates a level of acceptance for this type of promotional incentive in the service sector. Meanwhile, a study undertaken by PriceGrabber, a deal-of-the-day site, concluded that most users who search this type of discount portal are looking for services such as food and dining or entertainment and events (PriceGrabber 2012).

Similarly, in Spain, food and dining and services associated with personal care and beauty are those sectors that most employ discount coupon offers. However, coupon redemption varies significantly from one sector, the coupons not always being used. In the food and dining sector, the redemption rate ranges between 20 and 25 %, while in the family entertainment sector (leisure parks, cinema, etc.), the rate can be as high as 85 % (MarketingNews.es 2010).

Such figures evidence the current relevance of promotional incentives within firms' online marketing strategies. However, there appears to be a contradiction—or at least a tension—between the increase in firms' use of this tool online and their objective of creating and maintaining a given brand image. According to the literature on traditional sales promotion, this tool can damage brand image (Hennig-Thurau and Paul 2007), particularly due to its impact on the perceptions of quality in relation to the brand (Dodson et al. 1978; Mela et al. 1998; Yoo et al. 2000). This begs several questions: why is firms' use of this tool continually on the rise when it

can damage their brand image? is it possible that the effects of this promotional tool online are actually beneficial to the brand? and if this is the case, under what circumstances might the most positive impact be achieved? To the best of our knowledge, to date, there have been no academic studies analyzing how the use of different types of online promotional incentive can affect the creation of brand image; there only appears to be a few works examining their effect at a behavioral level (Chtourou et al. 2005; Fortin 2000; Hupfer and Grey 2005; Xie et al. 2004). At the same time, in the context of traditional media, the majority of studies examining the effect of such tools are based on the monetary sales promotions such as price discounts. However, the impact of the latter on consumer reference prices and on perceived service quality (Barry and O'Connor 1976; Garretson and Clow 1999) may be generating different results compared to non-monetary sales promotions such as free gifts. Yet, there are few existing studies undertaking a comparative analysis of the impact of monetary *versus* non-monetary sales promotions on brand image (Buil et al. 2013; Joseph and Sivakumaran 2008; Montaner and Pina 2008; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005), and none addressing this issue in the online context. The existing works conclude that the impact on brand image depends on whether the incentive concerned is monetary or non-monetary in nature, with the non-monetary type being the most suitable for building and enhancing brand image (Buil et al. 2013; Chandon et al. 2000; Joseph and Sivakumaran 2008; Martínez et al. 2007; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005).

On the Internet, sales promotion attracts the user's attention and can therefore encourage them to try a product; as such, it can be a powerful means of initiating a dialogue with the consumer (Whittaker 2001; Hupfer and Grey 2005). It can be supposed, therefore, that this type of promotion can have a major influence on the image of the brand being promoted.

The present work therefore endeavors to contribute to the knowledge base regarding the effectiveness of online sales promotions by examining in depth the differential effects of different online sales promotion types (online price discounts vs. free gifts).

Elsewhere, in traditional media, it has been demonstrated that the impact of sales promotions is influenced by promotion-proneness, particularly in terms of intention to purchase but also with regard to attitudes and perceptions (Palazón 2005; Yi and Yoo 2011; Montaner et al. 2011). According to Bawa and Shoemaker (1989), depending on the product/service category, the marketing environment, and the type of establishment, the same consumer will present different levels of promotion-proneness. It is logical to think, therefore, that perceptions of a sales promotion in the Internet context will differ from perceptions in traditional media, as will promotion-proneness. This latter variable will exert a moderating influence on the effectiveness of both types of sales promotion to generate a positive brand image.

In light of this, the aim of the present study was to examine the differential effects of online sales promotion (specifically, comparing an online price discount and free gift) on the brand image of a services firm, and to establish to what degree those effects may be moderated by an individual's promotion-proneness.

2 Literature review

2.1 Sales promotion type and brand image

It has been widely demonstrated that brand image plays a fundamental part in the consumer's decision-making process (Bitner 1991; Grönroos 1984; Gummenson and Grönroos 1988).

Keller (1993) defines brand image as "perceptions about a brand as reflected by the associations held in consumer memory." In the case of the Internet, this influence is all the more powerful given that consumers in this medium are highly susceptible to brand names (Danaher et al. 2003). This, in all likelihood, is due to two key factors. Firstly, the brand enables the consumer to synthesize the vast amount of information available online into concepts that are easy to assimilate and recall. As such, the brand helps the consumer to choose between all the different alternatives they encounter. Secondly, the brand helps the individual to reduce the perceived risk associated with their online purchase, by offering them an option that is familiar and that therefore seems safe (Chu et al. 2010; Tan 1999).

At the same time, it is understood that sales promotion involves a combination of communication tools designed to communicate the delivery—to an entity or an individual—of an added bonus to the service during a given period of time, as a means of achieving pre-planned communications objectives (adapted from Blattberg and Neslin 1990; Peattie and Peattie 1995). Bearing in mind this concept, it is widely accepted that the use of online sales promotion helps to create, reinforce, and maintain brand image. As a component of the marketing mix, sales promotion generates associations with the brand (Aaker 1991), influencing service differentiation (Kahn and McAlister 1997; Peattie and Peattie 1995) and helping to create and strengthen a given brand image (Matteson 1993).

A closer look at the literature dealing with the creation and maintenance of brand image in conventional media reveals that the use of sales promotions can erode or damage brand image, particularly when they are frequently implemented (Dodson et al. 1978; Mela et al. 1998; Yoo et al. 2000). Some authors, however, submit that they can have both positive and negative effects on consumers' evaluation of a brand, depending on their effectiveness at generating satisfaction or surprise, by offering an unexpectedly low price or adding value as a means of improving brand awareness (Chu and Keh 2006; Lo et al. 2005; Lowe 2010; Mandic 2009; Park and Lennon 2009; Tybout and Scott 1983).

Table 1 summarizes the studies that analyze the impact of sales promotion on brand image, in off-line media.

While it can be seen that both price discounts and free gifts have an impact on brand image, it is also clear that the two sales promotion types are different in nature. Price discounts are monetary promotions and thus focus the consumer's attention on price alone. This then becomes the main motive behind the purchase, such that in the process the perceived quality of the brand is reduced (Beirao 2001; Buil et al. 2013; Campbell and Diamond 1990; Garretson and Clow 1999; Martínez et al. 2007; Palazón and Delgado 2009). By contrast, free gifts are non-monetary promotions whose potential to appeal is derived from their suitability for the

Table 1 Findings regarding the impact of sales promotion on brand image

Authors	Findings
Aaker (1991) Faircloth et al. (2001) Keller (1993) Roth (1994)	All the variables of the marketing mix have an effect on the generation of brand associations
Dodson et al. (1978) Mela et al. (1998) Yoo et al. (2000)	Sales promotion can damage brand image
Davis et al. (1992)	There is no evidence to suggest that sales promotion generates more negative evaluations of the brand
Beirao (2001)	Monetary sales promotions do not generate favorable brand associations
Campbell and Diamond (1990)	Non-monetary sales promotions add value to the product/service
Darke and Chung (2005)	Monetary promotion negatively affects perceived quality when the actual quality of the product/service is not known
Hunt and Keaveney (1994)	Monetary promotion damages brand image when it provokes consumer dissatisfaction, and this dissatisfaction is attributed to the brand in question
Mela et al. (1998)	Non-monetary promotion does not affect brand differentiation
Raghubir and Corfman (1999)	Monetary promotion damages brand image when it is used by industries in which promotions are not typically employed
Raghubir (2004)	Monetary promotion affects perceived quality
Chu and Keh (2006)	Non-monetary promotions can help differentiate brands, communicating distinctive brand attributes, and contribute to the improved brand equity

Source: Own elaboration

consumer and their congruence with the service being promoted (Buil et al. 2013; Chandon et al. 2000; Joseph and Sivakumaran 2008; Martínez et al. 2007; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005) The two incentive types therefore generate different associations and thus affect brand image in different ways.

On this question of the influence of sales promotion type on brand image, some works address this issue in terms of traditional media (Beirao 2001; Buil et al. 2013; Campbell and Diamond 1990; Chandon et al. 2000; Jones et al. 2006; Joseph and Sivakumaran 2008; Martínez et al. 2007; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005; Raghubir and Corfman 1999). These studies conclude that the differences found may be due to the type of incentive itself, as the consumer's reactions and selection processes differ mainly according to the different benefits on offer. In this regard, Hunt and Keaveney (1994), basing their work on attribution theory (Bem 1965) and utility theory (Thaler 1983), conclude that when a price discount sets prices below the reference level of the consumer, they will naturally experience satisfaction with that price discount. These authors also affirm that the dissatisfaction derived from a price discount will always damage brand image if that dissatisfaction is attributed to the brand. The consumer may feel dissatisfied when the value of the price discount does not exceed the costs of obtaining it, or when the sales promotion does not offer prices below their personal reference point.

Further, the authors found that, when presented with price discounts, subjects did not generate favorable associations with the brand under analysis. The greatest number of associations was derived from the cheapest brand on the market, with the lowest service quality (Beirao 2001; Buil et al. 2013; Martínez et al. 2007; Montaner and Pina 2008).

Therefore, price discounts can generate a negative attitude toward the brand, as they make the consumer attribute their purchase to the discount offered and not to the qualities of the service or brand itself, thus leading to inferior evaluations of the brand (Davis et al. 1992). Such promotions are relatively easy to understand, and they increase the usefulness of the transaction as they are also easy to rationally evaluate. They also focus attention on the attribute of price. This leads the consumer to integrate them as part of the price of the service, which in turn means they may affect internal reference prices (Compeau and Grewal 1998; Diamond and Campbell 1989; Grewal and Compeau 1992) and thus damage brand image in the long term. In this way, consumer evaluations of price discounts will probably be more negative than in the case of free gifts as they raise the individual's price sensitivity and lower their reference prices (Mela et al. 1997, 1998; Ortemeyer and Huber 1990). Elsewhere, other authors have analyzed how, if an incentive other than discounts is used, it is possible that the effects on brand image may not be negative (Buil et al. 2013; Chandon et al. 2000; Diamond and Campbell 1989; Joseph and Sivakumaran 2008; Martínez et al. 2007; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005). Indeed, Diamond and Campbell (1989) affirm that non-monetary sales promotions add value to the product, as they provide it with an additional benefit that will give consumers increased satisfaction, which will therefore positively affect brand image.

More recently, authors including Buil et al. (2013) and Chandon et al. (2000) affirm that non-monetary sales promotions (such as free gifts) are deemed to be the most apt for generating positive brand image, as they generate unique associations around the brand that help to strengthen it (Chandon et al. 2000). This type of sales promotion almost always has a positive, stable effect on different product/service categories, and it is logical to assume, therefore, that free gifts will positively affect brand image.

Table 2 summarizes the main studies that have set out to compare the effect of monetary and non-monetary sales promotion on brand image, in traditional media.

2.2 Online sales promotion type and brand image

Despite the fact that there are clear differences between these two sales promotion types, few studies have examined their effects comparatively, and those that have done so focus on traditional media (Buil et al. 2013; Coker et al. 2010; Fogel and Thornton 2008; Joseph and Sivakumaran 2008; Martínez et al. 2007; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005).

In the case of the Internet, their findings need to be qualified as there are widely acknowledged differences between consumer behavior online and in traditional media. Internet users, compared to users of traditional media, are less price-sensitive, value convenience and ease of purchase more highly, and seek to reduce

Table 2 Findings regarding the effect of monetary, and non-monetary, incentives on brand image

Authors	Findings
Chandon et al. (2000)	Non-monetary promotions are the most appropriate for generating brand image
	Monetary promotions are more appropriate as a short-term incentive
Montaner and Pina (2008)	When frequently used, monetary promotion damages brand image. Over the long term, non-monetary promotion improves brand image
Buil et al. (2013)	Incentive type affects brand equity
Joseph and Sivakumaran (2008)	
Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester (2005)	
Joseph and Sivakumaran (2008)	Monetary and non-monetary promotions are useful to create brand equity because of their positive effect on brand knowledge structures. Non-monetary promotions are more appropriate as a brand-building activity
Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester (2005)	
Martínez et al. (2007)	Monetary promotions have a negative impact on brand image
	Non-monetary promotions may help reinforce brand equity
Buil et al. (2013)	Monetary promotions have a negative influence on perceived quality, whereas non-monetary promotions have a positive effect on perceived quality and brand associations. Monetary promotions have a nonsignificant impact on brand associations

Source: Own elaboration

the risk associated with the purchase, thus increasing brand loyalty (Castañeda et al. 2009; Degeratu et al. 2000; Jarvenpaa and Todd 1997; McMeekin et al. 2000; Messenger and Narashiman 1997).

There is very little academic literature examining the effects of online sales promotion on user behavior (Chtourou et al. 2005; Fortin 2000; Hupfer and Grey 2005; Xie et al. 2004). The works that do address this issue focus only on analyzing its effect at a conative level, in terms of generating attention and clickstream. It would seem that no work to date has examined the effect that different types of promotional incentives may have on brand image online, including the service sector.

The Internet is a uniquely special medium, not least because of its capacity to deliver huge volumes of information to the consumer. However, while it is true that the sheer volume of available information may generate "overload" for the user (Sicilia and Ruiz 2010), it is also the case that information creates more knowledge about a brand. This translates into specific associations with the brand; and these, once evaluated, are converted into attitudes toward it (Faircloth et al. 2001). In turn, this contributes to the generation of brand image.

Given that online sales promotions for given brands are commonplace, and that these promotions have the capacity to convey information about brands (Keller 1993), it is to be expected that they should have a direct effect in terms of brand image. In view of the absence of studies on this question, a useful conceptual

framework might involve the application of availability valence theory (Tybout and Scott 1983) and transformative learning theory (Mezirow 1978) to the online context, as well as the existing literature on online advertising. It seems logical to assume that, depending on how relevant the information conveyed by the online sales promotion is to the consumer, they will integrate it, to a greater or lesser extent, into their meaning structure and this will affect their attitudes. In turn, these attitudes will influence the formation of brand image as they are capable of generating feelings of pleasure or displeasure for the consumer that can be transferred to the brand (Aaker 1991; Keller 1993; Chandon et al. 2000; Beirao 2001; Faircloth et al. 2001; Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester 2005). According to the online advertising literature, clicks to display ads are the first indicator of the impact of this communication tool on brand image (Hollis 2005). Hence, in the case of online sales promotion, studies demonstrating that the inclusion of a sales promotion within a banner affects the CTR (Chtourou et al. 2005; Fortin 2000; Hupfer and Grey 2005; Xie et al. 2004) are helping to show that this tool does indeed have an effect on brand image.

Depending on the type of sales promotion concerned, the consumer will regard the promotion as a reduction in loss or as a gain, leading them to integrate, or not, the information provided into the price (Prospect Theory) (Kahneman and Tversky 1979) and therefore affecting in different ways the brand image. Monetary promotion affects the consumer's internal reference prices (Diamond and Campbell 1989) and can contribute to a devaluation in the perceived quality of the brand and thus to a devaluation of the brand overall. However, on the Internet, this type of sales promotion can have a very positive effect, because consumers perceive it as a "loss reducer" and this helps to lessen the perceived risk of online product acquisition, above all for those who are relatively unfamiliar with the medium, the brand, or the product.

Meanwhile, a non-monetary online sales promotion provides additional information, other than that related to price, regarding the characteristics of the incentive on offer and its relationship to the product being promoted. The relationship between the product and the incentive helps the brand to communicate information about the product's features or the benefits of using it (Rossiter and Bellman 2005), which in turn helps the consumer either to build a totally new brand image or to generate an improved existing brand image. For these reasons, it may be that online free gifts will achieve a more positive brand image than online price discounts as they add value and generate favorable associations toward the brand.

In light of the literature review, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H1 Online free gifts will generate a more positive brand image than online price discounts.

2.3 The moderating role of promotion-proneness

Studies in the realm of traditional media have repeatedly shown that promotion-proneness has a major influence on consumers' attitudes, perceptions, and behaviors (Palazón 2005; Yi and Yoo 2011). Promotion-proneness can be understood as "an

increased propensity to respond to a purchase offer because the form of the purchase offer positively affects purchase evaluations" (Lichtenstein et al. 1990). Elsewhere, Wakefield and Barnes (1996) define it as "a tendency to use sales promotion information as a basis for making patronage decisions."

Individuals who are more promotion-prone have a positive attitude toward promotional information and make use of this information in their decision-making process (Kono 1985; Palazón and Delgado-Ballester 2011). For them, the mere existence of a sales promotion is sufficient to drive their behavior toward concluding their search for alternatives and selecting the brand in question (DelVecchio 2005; Palazón 2005). This generates temporary, short-lived attitudes that do not affect brand image.

On the other hand, other authors consider that the most promotion-prone are, in fact, expert shoppers who will scrutinize in great detail each and every one of the benefits claimed in the promotional offer and factor these into their decision-making process (Webster 1965; Henderson 1994). In this scenario, it is less likely that such consumers will generate unfavorable attitudes toward the brand when presented with a sales promotion (Kumar et al. 1998).

However, while the Internet facilitates information search regarding features, prices, and offers, making it likely that sales promotion-proneness plays a determining role in online user behavior, it also increases the perceived risk associated with service acquisition (Laroche et al. 2005), making the consumer less price-sensitive (Chtourou et al. 2005). In other words, on the one hand, the Internet augments the effect of the consumer's promotion-proneness on their behavior by facilitating price and product comparison, and on the other hand, it dampens that effect due to the greater perceived risk associated with the service. This raises the question, then, of whether promotion-proneness moderates the effectiveness of online sales promotion in generating brand image. To date, no research appears to have answered this question. However, there are some authors who have endeavored to analyze whether coupon redemption behavior is the same online as offline (Jung and Lee 2010) and whether promotion-proneness affects the use of coupons online and the nature of the individual's viewing of the information (that is, active *vs*. passive) (Vicdan and Sun 2008). Jung and Lee (2010) demonstrate that the Internet boosts the coupon redemption rate compared to traditional media as it facilitates the consumer's use of coupons by reducing the time and effort required to search for them and save, organize, and redeem them. Therefore, it can be assumed that the Internet encourages promotion-prone behaviors when it presents online sales promotions as it reduces costs and increases the benefits of responding to a promotional initiative.

Elsewhere, Vicdan and Sun (2008) demonstrate that promotion-proneness influences how individuals view and use online sales promotions, and find that it is the most prone users who most readily expose themselves to this communication tool and who most actively use it. These authors conclude that promotion-proneness indirectly influences online purchasing. However, Wirtz and Chew (2002) find that promotion-proneness does not moderate the relationship between obtaining an incentive and e-word-of-mouth intention. They conclude that an individual's

intention to communicate a promotional offer or recommend a given purchase is independent of their level of promotion-proneness.

Meanwhile, it is worth noting that, in the Internet context, a greater number of cognitive operations is required to simply browse, compared to traditional media (Eveland and Dunwoody 2001; Sicilia and Ruiz 2010; Yu and Roh 2002), which suggests that, in general, an individual will endeavor to simplify their promotional information-processing as much as possible. Given that those who are more sales promotion-prone will be more involved with an online sales promotion, it is to be expected that they will process promotional information more via the central route compared to their less prone counterparts who will process more heuristically (Chandrashekaran and Grewal 2003; Schneider and Currim 1991). As a result, it is possible that the promotion-prone may generate a greater number of total, positive associations toward the brand and the service, thus affecting the brand image more positively than in the case of the less prone. The latter will generate a lower number of associations as they are less sensitive to, and less involved with, the sales promotion, and they dedicate fewer cognitive operations to the browsing process.

According to Zeithaml (1988) and DelVecchio (2005), those individuals who are more prone will interpret value in terms of the availability of discounts, such that they will select the brand under promotion without any complex processing of the quality–price relationship of different brands. Therefore, consumers who are more prone will value more positively those promotions that offer them a price discount, and will thus generate a more positive attitude and brand image when exposed to these than when exposed to a non-monetary sales promotion.

In light of the above, it would be logical to expect that the effect of online sales promotion type on brand image may differ, depending on the degree of promotion-proneness of the consumer in question.

The following hypothesis is therefore proposed:

H2 Promotion-proneness has a positive influence on the brand image generated as a result of exposure to an online sales promotion.

H3 Online price discounts will generate a more positive brand image than online free gifts among those users who are more promotion-prone.

3 Empirical study

In order to achieve the research objectives, a between-subjects experimental design was conducted, where the online sales promotion type was the independent variable with two levels of incentive: price discount (monetary) and free gift (non-monetary). The individuals within the sample were randomly classified into two groups, each group then being exposed to one of the incentive types only.

3.1 Selection of service and brand

When selecting the service category and the brand to be implemented in the experimental design, it was important to choose a service category about which the

target group was used to making purchase decisions, and that attracted similar levels of commitment and consumption for both males and females (Palazón and Delgado-Ballester 2011). Moreover, the service category would ideally be one that is widely purchased by the general population (Tan and Chua 2004), that offers highly frequent sales promotions (Alford and Biswas 2002), and that represents services that are not perceived as either totally hedonic or utilitarian. The aim here was to avoid the congruence between the service and the promotional incentive having any influence on the results (Chandon et al. 2000; Nunes and Park 2003). Therefore, the category "airline ticket" was chosen since it met these requirements and has been found to be one of the most widely purchased services on the Internet (Nielsen 2010). For the brand, it was decided that a very well-known brand should be selected for the experiment, so as to avoid possible bias in the results arising from consumer risk aversion. The brand finally chosen was Iberia, a major European airline.

3.2 Design of the promotional incentives

The incentive value was arrived at by following the ratio—20–50 % off the service price—suggested by several authors (Alford and Biswas 2002; Hardesty and Bearden 2003; Nunes and Park 2003; Tan and Chua 2004). Once the monetary value had been established, the researchers selected incentives that they believed would be appealing to Internet users (due to a good match with the benefits users seek, be these monetary in nature, or non-monetary) and also in line with the service on offer. According to the principle of compatibility (Tversky et al. 1988), complementarity between the chosen incentive and the service being promoted can affect user responses (Dowling and Uncles 1997; Tversky et al. 1988; Palazón and Delgado 2009; Roehm et al. 2002), making it important to select incentives that would be compatible with the service in terms of use. More specifically, a number of studies demonstrate that airline tickets and hotel accommodation are services that are typically purchased together (IAB Spain 2012). By taking this approach, the researchers hoped to maximize the chances of attracting the consumer's attention. The two specific incentives chosen for the experiment were therefore a discount of €120 on the flight (monetary sales promotion) and two free nights' accommodation with a national hotel chain (non-monetary sales promotion).

3.3 Selection of the promotional vehicle

According to a report by EyeBlaster (2010), airlines invest a high proportion of their budgets on display advertising. Specifically, in the case of Spain, in 2011, the transport, travel, and tourism sector was in fourth place in terms of advertising investment in display ads (8.9 %), with some airlines such as Vueling, Spanair, Iberia or Easyjet occupying the highest positions in the ranking of online advertising spend online (IAB Spain 2011). Another report (Admetrics 2013) shows that Iberia,

the brand chosen for the present study, focuses its advertising efforts on dynamic banners highlighting prices and the imminent end of the special offer. It is quite typical for airlines to place their banners on Web sites devoted to travel, news, and the economy (EyeBlaster 2010).

For these motives, the researchers opted to use banners as the vehicle for conveying the promotional incentives to the experimental subjects and to place them on a news site. On this basis, the site finally chosen for the present study was that of the Spanish daily newspaper *El Mundo* (www.elmundo.es), considered the leading digital daily in Spain.

Two layer banners were thus created for the experiment, one offering a monetary sales promotion (price discount of €120) and the other a non-monetary sales promotion, also with a value of approximately €120 (see Figs. 1, 2). As it was not possible to apply the experimental treatments to the real Web site of the electronic newspaper in question, an IT expert was briefed to create a Web application that could capture in real time the elmundo.es Web site and link it to a dedicated URL on a server used for the purposes of the experiment. The Web application consisted of two frames, on one of these, the real-time *El Mundo* Web page was uploaded, and on the other, ostensibly identical, page the promotional treatment was applied. By using this combination of frames, it was possible to achieve the effect of the promotion appearing on the newspaper's actual Web site.

3.4 Pretest

In order to establish the hedonic/utilitarian components of the selected service and of the incentive provided, a pretest was conducted on 90 individuals who shared the same characteristics as the target group. The scale proposed by Batra and Ahtola (1990), and implemented by Spangenberg et al. (1997) and Chandon et al. (2000), was applied to measure the service's characteristics. This scale considers the items pertaining to the utilitarian component to be *1. Practical/Impractical, 2. Essential/Nonessential:* and those for the hedonic component: *1. Fun/Boring, 2. Pleasant/Unpleasant*.

An index was determined by calculating the difference between the mean value of all utilitarian items and the mean of all hedonic items. A negative index score means that the evaluation of the product is primarily hedonic, while if the index score is positive, the product is qualified as utilitarian. The index obtained for the service "airline ticket" was −0.1271, indicating that its utilitarian and hedonic elements were of similar entity despite the hedonic component seemingly being dominant.

The researchers took advantage of this same pretest to ensure that the non-monetary sales promotion was indeed perceived to have a monetary value of approximately this amount, by using a one-sample t test with a reference value of 120. The results indicated that there were no significant differences as regards the perception of a value of €120 for the non-monetary promotion (non-monetary: $p > 0.5$).

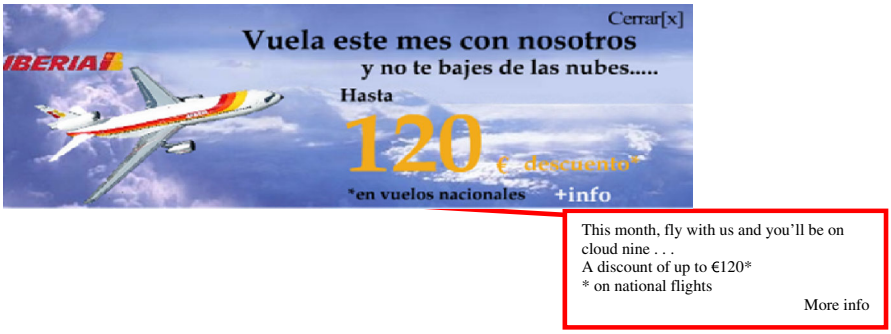

Fig. 1 Online price discount

Fig. 2 Online free gift

3.5 Organization of the fieldwork and sample

Due to the particular choice of service (airline ticket) and brand (Iberia), it was decided that the fieldwork should be conducted in two different geographical areas. The rationale for this was that the extent of subjects' prior knowledge of these categories could differ, depending on whether they came from provinces with large airports, small airports, or no airports; and this, in turn, could potentially affect their responses to the banner ad. To avoid this, the fieldwork was carried out in two locations—Madrid (home to Spain's largest airport) and Granada (the location of one of the lowest-ranking airports in Spain). In both instances, the decision was informed by the volume of air passengers registered, according to the 2012 annual report of Spanish airport management company AENA (2012).

The experiment itself was conducted at a number of Internet cafés that had been briefed previously on the process. For the purposes of the fieldwork, the research team contracted the services of an external company specializing in market research by means of personal surveys. Each of the interviewers was briefed in advance on the objectives of the research and the associated tasks. They were also assigned

gender and age quotas that they had to respect during the data capturing process, so as to guarantee the representativeness of the sample, in line with the Spanish Internet user profile (bearing in mind that this medium has reached a penetration level of 57.6 % in the Spanish population) (AIMC 2012).

The interviewers were asked to build the sample by randomly stopping passers-by in the area surrounding the Internet cafés being used for the experiment. Once a subject was identified, before being invited to enter the café, they were simply informed that they would be participating in a study by university researchers examining how people browse the Internet. Once inside, they were assigned a work station with a computer connected to a Web site with one of the two experimental treatments (that is, using one of two URLs), and they were invited to browse at leisure. The experiment was designed to match as closely as possible a real-life browsing situation; hence, participants were left to choose how they wanted to browse and which pages within the site they wanted to visit. While visiting the apparent *El Mundo* online newspaper, subjects were not aware that they were, in fact, browsing within an intranet. All the subjects participated freely without any type of incentive or subsequent compensation. After two-minute browsing, one of the banner advertisements popped up. The display ad used was a layer banner that appeared in the upper right-hand corner of the screen and moved downwards in a straight line. Subjects were able to choose whether to simply close the banner or click on it. Eight minutes after the banner appeared, whether the user had decided to click on it or not, an online questionnaire automatically appeared. This included the measures described in Sects. 3.4 and 4.1 and also covered the sociodemographic characteristics of the subject (that is, gender, age, income level, education level, motives for travel, frequency of Internet use, and nationality). The final sample obtained comprised 450 people, most of whom (71 %) had a monthly income of less than €1,500. The majority typically travelled for leisure purposes (67.75 %) used the Internet several times a day (36.83 %), or every day or almost every day (33.58 %), and were of Spanish nationality (81.66 %) (see Table 3).

Figure 3 outlines the key phases in the empirical study.

4 Results

4.1 Analysis of the psychometric properties of the scales

In order to test the proposed hypotheses, it was necessary to first examine the psychometric properties (validity and reliability) of the multi-item measurement scales used, with a view to calculating an indicative variable as each individual's average scoring for each item on the scale.

First, the validity of the content pertaining to the evaluation of the correspondence of the items on the scale with their conceptual definition was assessed (Hair et al. 2010). The present study uses scales that have been widely used previously in the academic literature.

Brand image was measured using a scale adapted from that of Yoo et al. (2000) and Aaker and Alvarez Del Blanco (1995). This was a 7-point Likert scale with

Table 3 Statistical description of the sample

	Sample (%)	Spanish Internet user population (%)
Gender		
Male	56.2	55.3
Female	43.8	44.7
Age		
Up to 19	18.6	11
From 20 to 44	64	62
45 years and over	18	27
Employment status		
Unemployed	6.0	
Student	47.0	
Employed	35.1	
Self-employed	7.3	
Housewife	2.2	
Retired	2.4	
Education		
Primary education only	6.1	
Secondary education	46.2	
Further education/ diploma	19.1	
Degree	27.1	
No formal education	1.2	
Monthly income		
Up to €499	56.7	
€500–€999	12.6	
€1,000–€1,499	15.0	
€1,500–€1,999	8.2	
€2,000–€2,499	3.2	
€2,500 and over	4.2	

three items: (1) *Iberia has a strong personality;* (2) *Iberia has a strong image; and* (3) *the intangible attributes of the Iberia brand are reason enough to buy it.*

To measure promotion-proneness, the present study used the scale of general promotion-proneness proposed by Lichtenstein et al. (1993) and applied by Palazón and Delgado-Ballester (2011) in the same geographical area: *I have a favorite brand, but most of the time I buy the brand that's on special offer; one should try to buy the brand that's on special offer; I am more likely to buy brands that are on special offer than those that are not; compared to most people, I am more likely to buy brands that are on special offer.*

Meanwhile, as various studies have demonstrated that brand familiarity can influence the results achieved by a sales promotion (DelVecchio et al. 2006), the researchers decided to control this variable so as to ensure that there was no

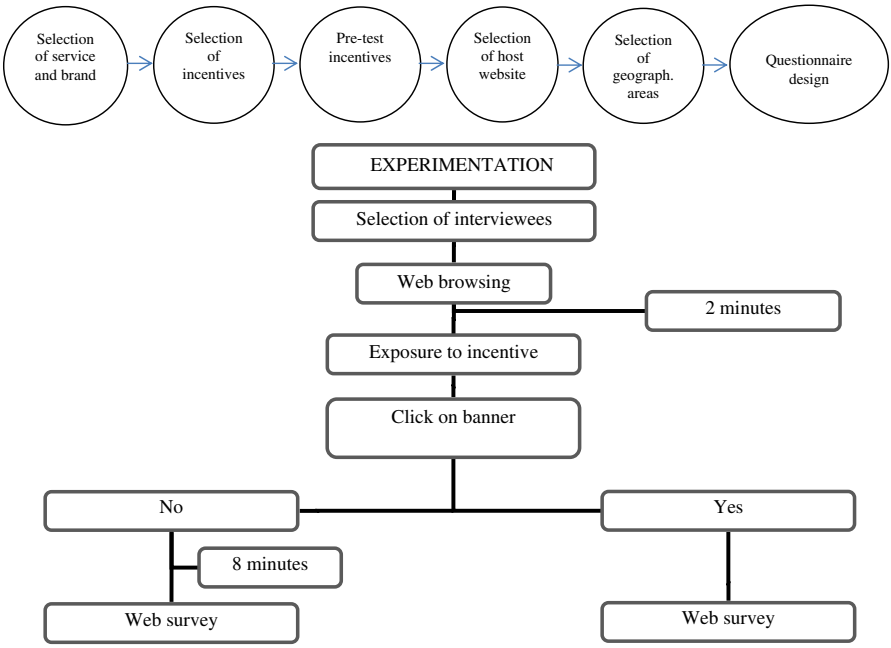

Fig. 3 Phases of the empirical study

differences in the composition of the experimental groups. The "brand familiarity" variable was measured using an adapted version of the scale proposed by Gefen (2000), consisting of a metric scale with a single-item Likert rating of 1 to 7: *How familiar do you consider yourself to be with purchasing Iberia plane tickets?*

Meanwhile, to examine the convergent validity of the "brand image" and "promotion-proneness" scales, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was used. It had previously been checked that the data did not follow a multinormal distribution, and thus the robust maximum likelihood method proposed by Satorra and Bentler (1986, 1988) was used. The analysis revealed that both the promotion-proneness scale and brand image scale had sound psychometric properties. All the parameters were significant, and composite reliability, variance extracted, and Cronbach's alpha were all above the recommended values. The goodness-of-fit indicators were also within the recommended limits (Hair et al. 2010) (See Tables 4, 5).

4.2 Manipulation check

Prior to testing the hypotheses, it was checked whether, in the sample, the monetary value associated with both incentives was perceived to be the same. Following the procedure applied by Nunes and Park (2003) and Palazón-Vidal and Delgado-Ballester (2005), as in the pretest, the researchers carried out a one-sample t test, the results showing that there were no differences in the perceived value of the two incentives (t:1.31; $p > 0.10$).

Table 4 Internal consistency of the scales

Indicator	Brand image	Promotion-proneness
Composite reliability	0.78	0.85
Average variance extracted (AVE)	0.54	0.59
Cronbach's α	0.76	0.85

Table 5 Goodness-of-fit indicators for the scales

Indicators	Brand image	Promotion-proneness	Acceptable limits
Chi-squared (*p* value)	0.43 (0.86)	0.54 (0.76)	Test significant
RMSEA (90 % RMSEA)	0.01; (0.–0.061)	0.02 (0.–0.052)	Values <0.08; the interval must not contain 1

The two groups of experimental subjects were distributed homogeneously both in terms of their composition and also their size (price discount, 230 individuals; free gift, 220 individuals).

Using the Kolmogorov–Smirnov test, it was also shown that there were no significant differences between the two groups ($p > 0.05$) as regards the key sociodemographic variables used in calculating the quotas (gender and age).

Prior to testing the hypotheses, the researchers also checked that there were no differences between the two sample groups in terms of promotion-proneness and brand familiarity. The average promotion-proneness (discount: 3.89; free gift: 3.75) and brand familiarity (discount: 3.92; free gift: 3.82) of the two groups were fairly equal. Therefore, there were not found to be any significant differences in terms of the average obtained by the two groups in relation to promotion-proneness and brand familiarity (F test, $p > 0.10$) (see Tables 6, 7).

4.3 Testing the hypotheses

A multiple regression analysis was undertaken, using the dependent variable "brand image" (abbreviated as BI), and two independent variables, namely "sales promotion type" and "promotion-proneness" (abbreviated as P). To achieve this, two new variables needed to be created. Firstly, given that the promotion type used was a nominal variable with two categories, it needed to be transformed into a numerical dummy variable in order to avoid the possibility of multicollinearity (Judge et al. 1988). This dummy variable, D, was codified as 0 if the user had not been exposed to the online price discount, and as 1 if they had been exposed to this type of sales promotion. Next, the variable reflecting the interactive effect between promotion-proneness and online price discount was created (Promotion-proneness × Price discount, PD). To avoid any possible problems of multicollinearity between variables, the recommendations of Aiken and West (1991) and Cohen and

Table 6 Group statistics

	Online sales promotion type	N	Mean	SD	SEM
Promotion-proneness	Discount	224	3.89	1.54	0.10
	Gift	216	3.75	1.67	0.11
Brand familiarity	Discount	225	3.92	2.18	0.14
	Gift	218	3.82	2.13	0.14

Table 7 *T* test for promotion-proneness and brand familiarity between sales promotion type

	Levene's test			*T* test for equality of means		
	F		Sig.	*t*	*df*	Sig. (two-tailed)
Promotion-proneness	Equal variances	3.01	0.08	0.88	438	0.37
	Not equal variances			0.88	432.21	0.37
Brand familiarity	Equal variances	0.03	0.84	0.50	441	0.61
	Not equal variances			0.50	440.97	0.61

Table 8 Multicollinearity results

	Collinearity statistics	
	Tolerance	VIF
(Constant)		
Online price discount (D)	0.99	1.00
Promotion-proneness standardized (P)	0.52	1.90
Online price discount × proneness standardized (PD)	0.52	1.89

Cohen (1983) were followed. The researchers standardized all the independent variables prior to estimating the interaction effect and the complete model (standardized promotion-proneness, ZP; standardized PD, ZPD).

The following model was thus to be tested:

$$\mathrm{BI} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 * \mathrm{D} + \beta_2 * \mathrm{ZP} + \beta_3 * \mathrm{ZPD} + \varepsilon \quad (1)$$

The parameters β_1 and β_2 would show the direct effect of online sales promotion type (H1) and promotion-proneness on BI (H2). Meanwhile, β_3 would show the interactive effect between promotion-proneness and sales promotion type on BI (H3).

Testing of the parameters was undertaken using the ordinary least-squares fit procedure. Following the estimation of the parameters, the conditions of validity of the estimation model were checked (normality, multicollinearity, and heteroscedasticity) (see Tables 8, 9, 10).

The proposed model obtained an adjusted R^2 of 0.11, which was significantly different from 0 ($p < 0.01$) (see Table 9). The model achieved an improvement in

Table 9 Diagnostic for collinearity between independent variables

Dimension	λ	Condition index
1	1.76	1.00
2	1.64	1.03
3	0.31	2.36
4	0.27	2.51

Table 10 Diagnostic for heteroscedasticity and independence of residuals

Durbin–Watson	1.76
White test	*p* value
Online price discount	0.94
Promotion-proneness	0.14
Online price discount × proneness	0.50

the prediction of brand image compared to the constant model. The F statistic indicates that using the model is better than guessing the mean ($p < 0.01$) (Freund et al. 2006; Norusis 2004). Thus, it can be affirmed that although the R^2 obtained is not high, it is nevertheless significant and representative of the proposed model. Similar studies have obtained similar, and even inferior, values (Ashton et al. 2010; Martínez-Ruiz et al. 2006, 2008; Naidoo and Ramseook-Munhurrun 2012; Phillips et al. 2008; Sophonsiri and Polyorat 2009; Wu et al. 2010). Online sales promotion affects BI, but its effect depends on the type of sales promotion employed and on the individual's level of promotion-proneness ($p < 0.05$) (see Table 11).

Table 12 shows that both online sales promotion type and also promotion-proneness have a direct and significant effect on brand image ($p < 0.05$). In this case, online free gifts (non-monetary online sales promotion) are more effective at generating a positive brand image than online price discounts (monetary online sales promotion) (β_1: -0.44, $p < 0.01$). Therefore, hypothesis H1 cannot be rejected. It was also found that it is the more promotion-prone individuals who register a more positive brand image (β_2: 0.13, $p < 0.05$). Therefore, hypothesis H2 cannot be rejected.

With regard to hypothesis H3, the results show that promotion-proneness affects the effectiveness of price discounts differently from that of free gifts (Table 12), with the linear regression slope being different for the discount compared to that of the gift (β_3: 0.45, $p < 0.01$). To graphically represent the effect of promotion-proneness, this variable was re-codified in three categories (low, medium, and high). The metric scale was sub-divided into three equal parts, on the basis that those

Table 11 Results of the model's goodness of fit: brand image

R^2	Adjusted R^2	F	Change statistics		
			p level for F change	gl1	gl2
0.11	0.10	17.13	0.00	3	422

Table 12 Coefficients for the model

	Coefficients (β)	Confidence interval for β (95 %)		t	p
		Lower	Upper		
(Constant)	5.16	4.99	5.31	61.82	0.00
Online price discount[a]	−0.13	−0.36	−0.09	−2.15	0.05
Promotion-proneness standardized	0.17	0.01	0.32	2.11	0.03
Online price discount × proneness Standardized[a]	0.40	0.17	0.63	3.49	0.01

[a] The reference category is free gift

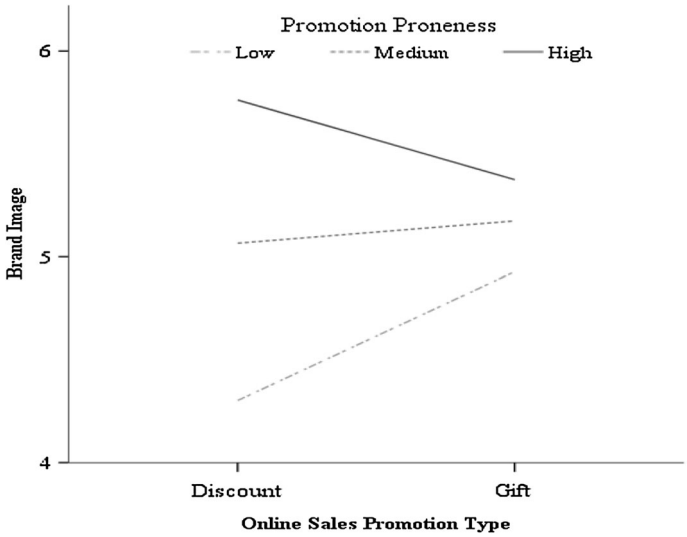

Fig. 4 Brand image predicted by sales promotion-proneness and online sales promotion type

individuals who scored values lower than 3 on the original scale had a low level of promotion-proneness, those scoring between 3 and 5 had a medium level of promotion-proneness, and those with scores over 5 had a high level of promotion-proneness (see Fig. 4). These findings demonstrate that promotion-proneness has a much greater effect on the effectiveness of online price discounts at generating positive brand image than on the effectiveness of online free gifts. In fact, its effect on online price discounts is almost triple that registered for free gifts. Furthermore, in the case of the online price discount, the greater the promotion-proneness, the more positive the brand image. The opposite is true in the case of the online free gift: those individuals who were less promotion-prone obtained a more positive brand image (see Table 12). Hence, it can be affirmed that promotion-proneness is moderating the relationship between the type of sales promotion employed and the brand image generated. These findings suggest that H3 is supported.

5 Conclusions and implications

The findings of the present work lead the researchers to conclude that online sales promotion type has a significant effect on brand image. On the one hand, online sales promotion affects brand image, and on the other hand, this influence differs depending on the online sales promotion type (monetary vs. non-monetary). An original finding is that online sales promotion does not necessarily generate a negative brand image, in contrast to the findings from the literature on traditional media (Dodson et al. 1978; Mela et al. 1998; Yoo et al. 2000). This result supports the idea that it is possible to contribute to brand image-building by using suitable promotional incentives on the Internet. It may be that the difference is due to the fact that, on the Internet, discounts do not perform an informative function for the user. It is when the consumer users the sales promotion as information that brand image suffers (Raghubir and Corfman 1999). According to these authors, whether the discount will have a negative impact on image or not will depend on past promotional history, individual expertise in the category, and perceptions of how common promotions are in a given industry, among other variables. Given that in the commercial airline sector the use of price discounts and price wars are relatively common (Franke 2004; Hayes and Ross 1998; Karnani and Wernelfelt 1985; Terrence 1990), it is to be expected that the impact of this type of incentive would not adversely affect brand image. At the same time, it may be that when a brand enjoys sufficient recognition and "weight" in the market of reference, as is the case with the Iberia airline brand, its image is not adversely affected by price discounts (Della Bitta et al. 1981; Sawyer and Dickson 1984). It may therefore be the case that, in the online context, as users tend to have relatively frequent contact with different sales promotions and typically select better-known brands as a means of reducing the risk associated with service acquisition (Degeratu et al. 2000), online discounts do not have such a negative influence on brand image.

A further original contribution made by the present work derives from its comparative analysis of different online sales promotion types. In general, previous studies have focused on one single sales promotion type, namely general discounts in traditional media, and coupons in digital media. The present study goes a step further, by comparing the impact on image depending on the benefit offered via the promotional incentive (that is, utilitarian or hedonic). It is found that brand image differs depending on whether the online sales promotion is a free gift or a price discount—the former being more apt for achieving positive brand image.

Therefore, it can be affirmed that, in the online medium, free gifts are the more effective of the two approaches in terms of creating positive brand images. Complementarity between service type and promotional incentive helps the user to construct a more positive brand image than in the case of discounts as it enhances their perception of the utility of the transaction.

This finding helps to broaden the existing knowledge on the effects of online sales promotion within the airline sector and, by extension, the service sector as, to date, no such studies have been undertaken. The results of the work contribute to understanding consumer behavior in response to an online sales promotion, and fill a gap in the sales promotion literature. Furthermore, these results can help marketing

managers to design online promotional campaigns for airlines brands more efficiently, depending on the objectives concerned. More specifically, the present research will help managers to select the most appropriate online sales promotion type for reaching different consumer groups, depending on their promotion-proneness, in line with the needs and objectives of the firm.

However, it should be noted that the effect of online sales promotion on brand image varies according to the user's promotion-proneness.

When the consumer's promotion-proneness is taken into account, it becomes clear that there are differences relating to the types of incentive applied (price discount or free gift). The greater the consumer's promotion-proneness, the more effective the online price discount becomes at creating a positive image. However, in the case of those users who are less promotion-prone, online price discounts generate a more negative brand image than free gifts. This finding affirms the assertions of Kumar et al. (1998) in relation to traditional media, and contradicts those of DelVecchio (2005), who considers that for promotion-prone individuals, sales promotion is unable to affect brand image.

Once again, it is likely that this phenomenon arises when the consumer uses the online sales promotion as an information source. On this basis, as promotion-prone users are "experts" in the given service category, they are less likely to use price discount as an information source; thus, reference prices and perceptions of brand quality among these users will remain unaffected by the sales promotion, and monetary promotion will generate a more positive image than free gifts. By contrast, users who are less promotion-prone will use the price discount as information about the brand, which will generate a less positive brand image in response to exposure to a promotional gift.

One implication of particular interest that can be drawn from the present work is that, given the greater promotion-sensitivity that derives from utilitarian services categories compared to that of hedonic services categories (Inman and McAlister 1993; Wakefield and Inman 2003), it is advisable to use online price discounts rather than free gifts. Furthermore, as the typical promotion-prone consumer appears to be young, with a low-to-medium educational level, a low-to-medium income level, and residing in an urban setting (Ailawadi et al. 2001; Bawa et al. 1997; Lichtenstein et al. 1997), the recommended promotion type for this kind of consumer is online price discount, with free gifts recommended for all other types of user.

Online sales promotion, then, can be a useful tool for creating or reinforcing a specific brand image, and so it is important to understand how the different online sales promotion types impact on that image. Marketing managers need to be aware that, depending on the type of incentive they choose to offer, their online sales campaign will prove more, or less, effective, even with the same budget. As the present work demonstrates, an online sales promotion not only has an effect on behaviors but also on the consumer's level of affect, which helps to build or reinforce the firm's brand image. For this reason, it is recommended that when the aim is to promote a brand or a Web site, then online sales promotions should be used as these are capable of attracting the consumer's attention.

That said, prior to designing and planning an online promotional campaign, marketers should carefully consider this question and analyze in detail the value that the chosen sales promotion type may deliver. In this sense, it is advisable to apply non-monetary online promotions as these have a more positive effect on the brand image, helping to generate associations between the incentive being offered and the brand being promoted. At the same time, when designing such a promotional campaign, it is important to bear in mind the degree of promotion-proneness of the target audience, given that this negatively affects repeat purchasing and the consumer's level of loyalty (Alford and Biswas 2002). Where this characteristic remains unknown by the firm, or when there is a need to avoid its collateral effects on repeat purchasing and consumer loyalty, once again it is advisable to opt for non-monetary online sales promotions, given that their effect on brand image is more stable and positive than in the case of monetary online sales promotions (Chandon et al. 2000). At the same time, when the firm wishes to capture new users online and create a brand image among them, it should use non-monetary online sales promotions. It is also recommended that this type of promotion be used when the aim is to reinforce the brand image held by habitual users of the brand on the Internet. However, if the firm wishes to attract promotion-prone consumers in order to, for example, generate quick sales of end-of-line or past-season services, it is better to use monetary online sales promotions as these are shown to be more favorable to brand image in this case.

Finally, there are certain limitations to the present work that are important to bear in mind. First, the user's general opinion of the promotional banner itself may be exercising a moderating effect on the results obtained. It would therefore be interesting to analyze, in future studies, how attitude toward the promotional vehicle communicating the incentive may affect results in terms of brand image. Second, the present research does not consider the possible effect of general opinions about the Internet as a medium or attitudes toward the particular Web site where the promotional banner was placed.

Meanwhile, the study was based on one single service category, airline tickets. As commented on earlier, the frequency with which sales promotions are used by the sector will determine whether their impact on brand image is positive or negative, with the impact being more negative when they are used in sectors where this approach is only seen infrequently (Raghubir and Corfman 1999). As airlines regularly use promotional incentives, it would be necessary to replicate the study in other service sectors in which, by contrast, the use of promotional incentives is not so habitual. This would help establish whether the findings of the present research still hold true. Furthermore, given the characteristics of promotion-proneness, it is possible that a change in service category would give different results. It would be of interest to repeat the study using different categories so as to analyze whether the effects of the chosen incentives remain the same, and whether promotion-proneness affects the relationship between incentive type and brand image in the same way. It would also be of value to analyze whether the results are transferrable to brands with differing levels of online awareness. In other words, given that the level of brand awareness affects the consumer's perception of risk and the negative impact of certain sales promotions on that perception (Raghubir and Corfman 1999), it would

be of interest to understand how this variable affects the effectiveness of online promotions. Finally, given the importance of sales promotion-proneness in influencing the effect of online sales promotion, it would be helpful to analyze how to identify those users who are promotion-prone online and to understand their core characteristics.

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